And these ruts were made by imperial Roman chariots—just wide enough to accommodate the behinds of two war horses hitched to the chariots.

The standard gauge of 4 feet 8½ inches—also called the Stephenson Gauge after George Stephenson, the International Gauge or the Normal Gauge—is the most widely used railway gauge in the world today, with about 55 per cent of railway lines using this.

But let's come back to India. In January 1851, when the question of choosing a gauge for India arose, Lord Dalhousie, who, at thirty-six years of age, had taken over as India's youngest Governor General and was the key promoter of railways in India, selected a gauge of 5 feet 6 inches. Dalhousie wanted a gauge wider than Britain's. It was thought that it would allow more people and wares to be transported, and give stability to the trains. The dimensions had an overall impact on land-acquisition deals and related procedures, and with its quick spread across the subcontinent, this became the standard width of the tracks in India. [75] This is today known as the Indian broad gauge.

A NUMBERS GAME

Initially, trains and railway lines were feared and Indians were sceptical of the railways. But once trains were plying across the country with speed and precision, everyone wanted to take one. The rich maharajas and businessmen wanted to have their own trains and lines. Within a decade of the first run in 1853, the railways in India had caught everyone's attention.

In 1862, Shrimant Maharaja Sir Khanderao II Gaekwad, the Maharaja of Baroda, opened his own railway—an 8-mile network of small trains that ran on tracks just 2 feet 6 inches wide, from Dabhoi to Miyagam. Initially, he did not have locomotives, so he got oxen to run his trains—and surprisingly this proved quite successful. This became India's first narrow gauge railway line.

A decade later, in the early 1870s, Governor General Lord Mayo was impressed with the advantages smaller railways offered, and found them more affordable and viable in smaller townships, where traffic was not too heavy. He encouraged a gauge of 3 feet 3 inches, and termed it the metre gauge to encourage use of the metric system.

Soon, rail tracks and trains of different sizes began to crop up in various parts of the country, breaking the uniform national rail gauge and